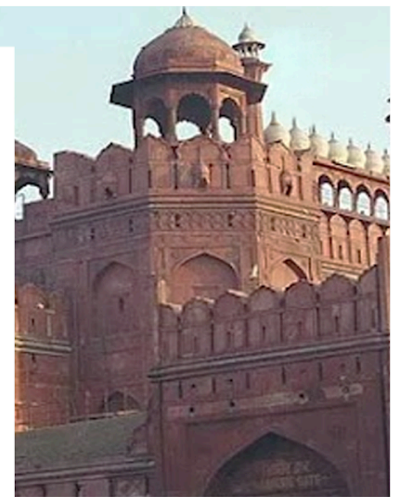
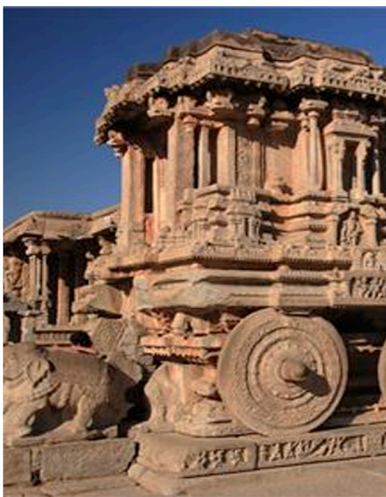


General Knowledge

Medieval History

STUDY NOTES

SIKHISM



SIKHISM



Sikh Movement and Its Origin

- The **Sikh Movement** originated during the **medieval period** when **Guru Nanak** founded Sikhism, which initially began as a **minor sect** and later developed into a **prominent religion** over centuries.
- The religion evolved through the teachings of **ten successive Gurus**, with all Gurus being seen as **embodiments of the same divine light**.
- The Sikh Movement reached its **climax with the creation of the Khalsa** by the **tenth Guru, Guru Gobind Singh**.
- Sikhism emerged at a time when there were **conflicts between the two dominant religious traditions of Hinduism and Islam** in India.
- Guru Nanak is often depicted as a **reconciler of the two conflicting traditions**, emphasizing love, unity, and equality.
- After his **enlightenment in Sultanpur in 1496**, Guru Nanak travelled widely to **spread the message of love and brotherhood**.
- The **followers of Sikhism** steadily increased during the **16th century** under the leadership of his **successors**, including people from **various castes**, such as **traders, artisans, agriculturists, and craftsmen**.

- **Amritsar (then Ramdasapur)** emerged as a prominent centre for the Sikh community by the early **17th century**, with the construction of the **Harmandir Sahib (Golden Temple)**.
- The **Sikh community in Amritsar** functioned as a **self-governing entity**, which historians refer to as a '**state within the state**' during that period.

Guru Nanak: Life, Teachings, and Contributions

- **Birth and Early Life:**
 - Guru Nanak was born in **1469 CE** in **Talwandi** (present-day **Nankana Sahib** in Pakistan), into the **Bedi gotra**.
 - He received early education in **Sanskrit and Persian**, showing an inclination towards spirituality from a young age.
- **Rejection of Rituals and Social Inequalities:**
 - Guru Nanak **rejected the authority of the Vedas** and preached the **concept of One God** as the **supreme, formless, all-powerful, and truthful creator**.
 - He **denounced caste distinctions and ritualistic practices** like **bathing in holy rivers**, promoting **equality for all human beings**, including women.
 - He emphasized that **honour and caste** should be judged by a person's **actions and deeds** rather than birth.
- **Practical and Ethical Religion:**
 - Guru Nanak's vision of religion was **highly practical and ethical**. He urged people to abandon **selfishness, falsehood, and hypocrisy** and live a life of **truth, honesty, and kindness**.
 - He advocated a life of **justice, righteousness, and liberty**, guiding people with the principles:
 - **Sach (Truth)**
 - **Halal (Lawful earning)**
 - **Khair (Wishing well of others)**
 - **Niyat (Right intention)**
 - **Service to the Lord**
 - His famous saying, "**Abide pure amidst the impurities of the world,**" exemplifies his practical approach to spirituality.
- **Foundational Elements of Guru Nanak's Philosophy:**
 - His philosophy revolved around **three core elements**:
 - **The Guru (Charismatic Personality)**

- **Shabad (Ideology)**
- **Sangat (Community or Congregation)**
- **Rejection of Idol Worship and Ritualism:**
 - Guru Nanak **repudiated idol worship** and rejected the idea of **pilgrimages** or **incarnations of divinity**.
 - He condemned **formalism and ritualism**, promoting **devotion and ethical conduct** over ceremonies.
- **Concept of Langar (Community Kitchen):**
 - Guru Nanak introduced the **Langar system**, a **community kitchen** where people, irrespective of caste or social status, shared meals together, promoting **social equality**.
- **Core Precepts of Guru Nanak's Teachings:**
 - **Nam Japna:** Continuous contemplation and remembrance of **One God**.
 - **Kirat Karna:** Earning an honest living through righteous means.
 - **Vand Chhakna:** Sharing one's earnings with the community and the needy.
- **Summary of Guru Nanak's Teachings:**
 - Belief in **One True Lord**.
 - **Worship of God's Name** as the path to liberation.
 - **Necessity of a Guru** to guide in worship and spiritual growth.
 - Conceptualizing God as both **Nirguna (without attributes)** and **Nirankar (formless)**.

Ten Sikh Gurus

Guru	Period	Birthplace	Key Contributions
Guru Nanak	1469–1539 CE	Nankana Sahib (Pakistan)	Founded Sikhism, rejected caste, introduced Langar and Nam Japna, Kirat Karna, Vand Chhakna .
Guru Angad	1539–1552 CE	Muktsar, Punjab	Standardized Gurmukhi script ; strengthened Langar system.
Guru Amardas	1552–1574 CE	Basarke, Amritsar	Abolished sati , promoted widow remarriage ; divided the community into 22 Manjis .

Guru Ramdas	1574–1581 CE	Lahore, Pakistan	Founded Amritsar ; introduced Anand Karaj , the Sikh marriage code.
Guru Arjan Dev	1581–160 6 CE	Goindwal, Punjab	Compiled Adi Granth ; built Harmandir Sahib ; first Sikh martyr.
Guru Hargobind	1606–164 4 CE	Wadali, Punjab	Introduced Miri-Piri ; founded Akal Takht ; transformed Sikhs into a martial community.
Guru Har Rai	1644–166 1 CE	Kiratpur, Punjab	Sheltered Dara Shikoh ; known for his kindness and compassion.
Guru Har Kishan	1661–1664 CE	Kiratpur, Punjab	Died of smallpox while healing the sick in Delhi; known as the child guru .
Guru Tegh Bahadur	1665–1675 CE	Amritsar, Punjab	Martyred for opposing forced conversions by Aurangzeb; spread Sikhism to Bihar and Assam .
Guru Gobind Singh	1675–170 8 CE	Patna, Bihar	Founded Khalsa , the warrior order; passed Guruship to Guru Granth Sahib .

Guru Angad (1539–1552 CE)

- **Birth Name:** Bhai Lehna.
- Guru Angad **developed the Gurmukhi script** and promoted its use for **religious texts** in Sikhism.
- He **strengthened the Langar tradition** (community kitchen) to promote equality and service.
- Guru Angad **opened new schools** to spread education among the Sikhs.
- He **established the Mall Akhara**, a physical and spiritual training centre, to promote well-being.

Guru Amardas (1552–1574 CE)

- Guru Amardas **abolished the practice of sati** and encouraged **widow remarriage**.
- He **established the Piri system**, empowering women with leadership roles.

- Guru Amardas **divided the Sikh community into 22 Manjis (districts)** for better administration.
- He **advocated against the purdah system**, which required women to wear veils.
- He persuaded **Emperor Akbar to abolish the pilgrim tax** for non-Muslims.

Guru Ramdas (1574–1581 CE)

- Guru Ramdas **founded the town of Chak Ramdaspur**, which later became **Amritsar**.
- He **initiated the construction of the Harmandir Sahib (Golden Temple)** on land donated by Akbar.
- He composed the **Anand Karaj**, the Sikh marriage code, and emphasized the **rejection of superstitions** in religious practices.



Guru Arjan Dev (1581–1606 CE)

- Guru Arjan Dev **compiled the Adi Granth**, which later became the **Guru Granth Sahib**, the holy book of Sikhs.
- He **completed the construction of Harmandir Sahib (Golden Temple)** and developed the towns of **Taran Taran** and **Kartarpur**.
- He was **executed by Jahangir** for supporting Jahangir's rebellious son **Khusrau**, becoming the **first Sikh martyr**.



Guru Hargobind (1606–1644 CE)

- Guru Hargobind introduced the concepts of **Miri-Piri**, representing **temporal and spiritual authority**.
- He **founded the Akal Takht** in Amritsar and transformed the Sikhs into a **martial community**.
- He **waged wars against Mughal rulers Jahangir and Shah Jahan** and defeated the Mughal army in battle.

Guru Har Rai (1644–1661 CE)

- Guru Har Rai **gave shelter to Dara Shikoh**, the brother of Aurangzeb, which led to persecution from the Mughals.
- He was known for **healing the sick** and promoting **compassion and kindness**.

Guru Har Kishan (1661–1664 CE)

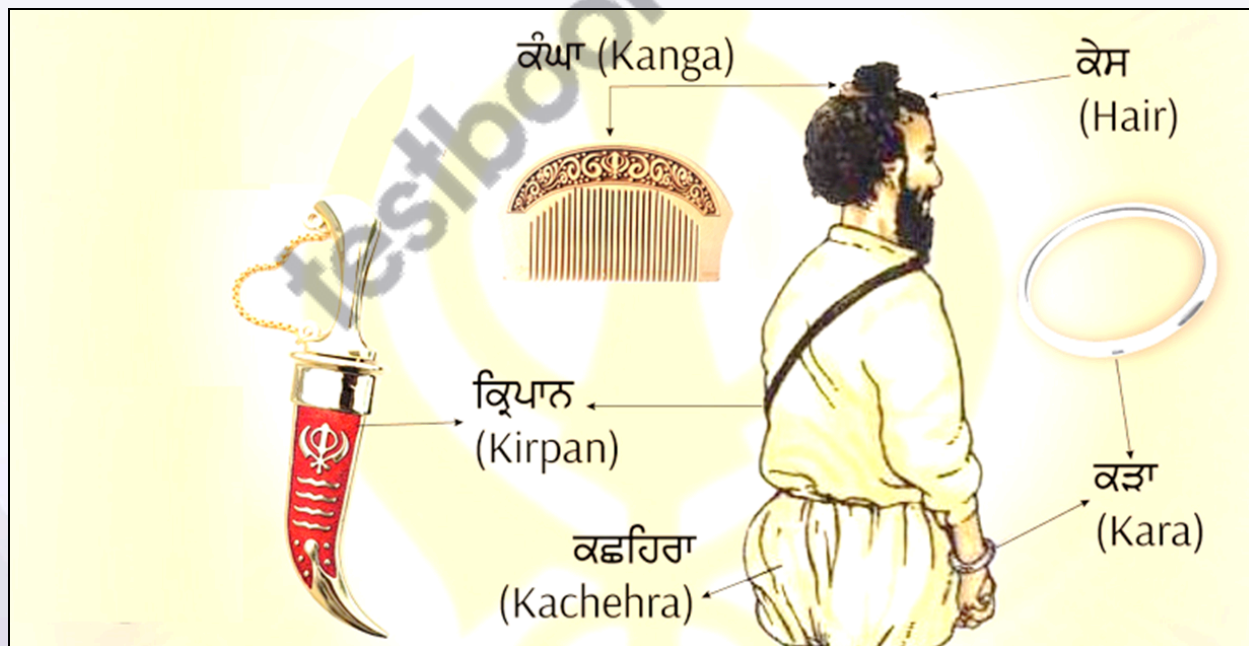
- Guru Har Kishan became the **Guru at the age of 5 years**, earning the title of the **Child Guru**.
- He **died of smallpox** while healing people during an epidemic in Delhi.
- **Gurudwara Bangla Sahib** in Delhi is dedicated to his memory and service to humanity.

Guru Tegh Bahadur (1665–1675 CE)

- Guru Tegh Bahadur was **beheaded by Aurangzeb** for **opposing the forced conversion of Kashmiri Pandits** to Islam.
- His **place of martyrdom is marked by Sis Ganj Sahib Gurudwara** in Chandni Chowk, Delhi.
- He **expanded Sikhism** beyond Punjab, spreading the faith to **Bihar and Assam**.

Guru Gobind Singh (1675–1708 CE)

- Guru Gobind Singh **founded the Khalsa** in **1699 CE** to unite Sikhs and instill **discipline and courage** among them.
- He introduced the **Five K's** as essential articles of faith for Sikhs:
 - **Kesh:** Uncut hair.
 - **Kangha:** Wooden comb.
 - **Kara:** Iron bracelet.
 - **Kachera:** Cotton undergarment.
 - **Kirpan:** Iron dagger.



- He **declared that the Guru Granth Sahib** would be the **eternal Guru** of the Sikhs, ending the line of living Gurus.

- Guru Gobind Singh **passed away in Hazur Sahib** after being stabbed by an assassin sent by the Mughal governor **Wazir Khan**.

Gurdwaras and Takhts (Seats of Authority)

Takht	Location	Significance
Akal Takht Sahib	Amritsar, Punjab	Founded by Guru Hargobind ; seat of spiritual and temporal authority .
Takht Sri Keshgarh Sahib	Anandpur Sahib, Punjab	Birthplace of the Khalsa in 1699 CE .
Takht Sri Damdama Sahib	Talwandi Sabo, Punjab	Place where Guru Granth Sahib was completed by Guru Gobind Singh .
Takht Sri Hazur Sahib	Nanded, Maharashtra	Final resting place of Guru Gobind Singh .
Takht Sri Patna Sahib	Patna, Bihar	Birthplace of Guru Gobind Singh .

Teachings of Sikhism

- **Belief in One God:** Sikhism is **monotheistic**, emphasizing that God is **formless (Nirankar)** and **attribute-less (Nirguna)**.
- **Equality:** All humans are **equal**, irrespective of **caste, gender, or religion**.
- **Service and Sharing:** Sikhs are encouraged to **share their earnings** and serve the community through **Langar**.
- **Moral Life:** Emphasis on **truthfulness, justice, and humility** in daily life.
- **Karma and Rebirth:** Life is governed by **karma**, and the soul aims to unite with the Divine.

Sacred Sikh Institutions and Takhts

Type	Name	Location	Significance
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Takht (Seats of Divine Authority)	Akal Takht Sahib	Amritsar, Punjab	Founded by Guru Hargobind ; represents spiritual and temporal authority .
	Takht Sri Keshgarh Sahib	Anandpur Sahib, Punjab	Birthplace of the Khalsa in 1699 CE.
	Takht Sri Damdama Sahib	Talwandi Sabo, Punjab	Completion site of the Guru Granth Sahib by Guru Gobind Singh.
	Takht Sri Hazur Sahib	Nanded, Maharashtra	Final resting place of Guru Gobind Singh.
	Takht Sri Patna Sahib	Patna, Bihar	Birthplace of Guru Gobind Singh.
Gurdwara (Doorways to the Guru)	Golden Temple (Harmandir Sahib)	Amritsar, Punjab	Founded by Guru Ram Das and completed by Guru Arjun Dev ; the most sacred Sikh shrine.
	Bangla Sahib	Delhi	Associated with Guru Har Kishan .
Other Prominent Gurdwaras	Gurdwara Paonta Sahib	Himachal Pradesh	Significant pilgrimage site.
	Gurdwara Rakab Ganj Sahib	New Delhi	Holds historical significance.
	Gurdwara Sis Ganj Sahib	Delhi	Marks the martyrdom site of Guru Tegh Bahadur .
	Hemkund Sahib	Uttarakhand	The pilgrimage site is surrounded by mountains and a sacred lake.

Origins and the Formation of Misls

- **End of Guru Gobind Singh's Era and Creation of Khalsa (1699):**
 - **Guru Gobind Singh**, the tenth Guru, transformed the Sikh community into a **martial brotherhood** known as the **Khalsa**.
 - After his death in 1708, the Sikhs faced continuous **Mughal persecution**, leading to **decentralization** of leadership and emergence of **small military units**.
- **Formation of the Misls (Early 18th Century):**
 - **Misls** were **confederacies** or groups of Sikh warriors formed to protect Sikh territories and expand their influence.
 - Each misl was governed by a **Sardar (chief)** and maintained its **independent army**, but they operated under the shared identity of the Khalsa.
 - There were **12 prominent Misls**, some of the well-known ones being:
 - **Ahluwalia Misl**
 - **Bhangi Misl**
 - **Ramgarhia Misl**
 - **Kanheya Misl**
 - **Phulkian Misl**
 - **Sukerchakia Misl**
- **Purpose of the Misls:**
 - The Misls were established to **defend Sikh territories** from **Mughal and Afghan invasions** and **expand Sikh influence** across Punjab.
 - They operated with a **democratic system** in which the chiefs collectively made important decisions for the community.

Rising to Power: Unification of Misls and the Establishment of the Sikh Empire

Ranjit Singh and the Sukerchakia Misl:

- **Ranjit Singh**, born in 1780, was the leader of the **Sukerchakia Misl**.
- He demonstrated exceptional leadership, military skill, and diplomacy from a young age and gradually gained prominence in Punjab.
- Ranjit Singh unified various **competing misls** under his command through **alliances, diplomacy, and conquests**.

Conquest of Lahore (1799):

- In 1799, **Ranjit Singh captured Lahore**, the political and economic centre of Punjab, marking the beginning of his reign as the **Maharaja of Punjab**.
- Lahore became the **capital of the Sikh Empire**.

Formation of the Sikh Empire (1801):

- By 1801, **Ranjit Singh was declared the Maharaja of the unified Sikh Empire**, formally establishing **sovereign Sikh rule** in Punjab.
- The Sikh Empire, under Ranjit Singh, extended from **Peshawar in the west to Kashmir in the north** and **Sindh in the south**.

Golden Era of the Sikh Empire under Ranjit Singh

- **Military Reforms:**
 - Ranjit Singh **modernized the Sikh army** by hiring **European officers**, including **French and Italian generals**, to train his soldiers.
 - His army was known as the **Khalsa Army**, which combined **traditional Sikh warriors** with **modern military tactics**.
- **Religious Tolerance and Administration:**
 - Ranjit Singh was known for his **religious tolerance**, appointing Hindus, Muslims, and Sikhs to important administrative positions.
 - He ensured that **temples, mosques, and gurdwaras** were equally protected and funded by the state.
 - The **Harmandir Sahib (Golden Temple)** was beautified and covered with **gold leaf** under his patronage.
- **Territorial Expansion:**
 - Ranjit Singh's conquests included:
 - **Multan** in 1818.
 - **Kashmir** in 1819.
 - **Peshawar** in 1823.
 - His empire extended to the **Khyber Pass**, making the Sikh Empire the most powerful kingdom in northwestern India.
- **Diplomacy and Peace with the British:**

- Ranjit Singh maintained **peaceful relations with the British East India Company** and signed the **Treaty of Amritsar in 1809**, which recognized his sovereignty over Punjab.

Decline and Fall of the Sikh Empire

- **Death of Ranjit Singh (1839):**
 - **Ranjit Singh's death in 1839** marked the beginning of **instability and power struggles** within the Sikh Empire.
 - His successors were weak and unable to maintain unity among the factions.
- **Internal Conflicts and Court Intrigues:**
 - After Ranjit Singh's death, the empire was plagued by **succession disputes and court intrigues**.
 - His successors, including **Kharak Singh, Nau Nihal Singh, and Sher Singh**, were **either assassinated or deposed** within a short period.
- **British Interference:**
 - The British, taking advantage of the internal strife, began **meddling in Sikh affairs**.
 - **Rani Jindan**, the regent for her young son **Duleep Singh**, tried to resist British control, but the internal weaknesses made the empire vulnerable.
- **Anglo-Sikh Wars (1845–1849):**
 - The **First Anglo-Sikh War** (1845–1846) resulted in the **Treaty of Lahore**, which reduced the Sikh Empire's territory.
 - The **Second Anglo-Sikh War** (1848–1849) led to the **annexation of Punjab** by the British East India Company.
- **Annexation of Punjab (1849):**
 - In **1849**, Punjab was formally **annexed** by the British, marking the **end of the Sikh Empire**.
 - **Duleep Singh**, the last Maharaja of the Sikh Empire, was exiled to England, and Punjab became a part of **British India**.

Conclusion

The **Sikh Empire** emerged from the **misl**s, which were united by **Maharaja Ranjit Singh** into a powerful and prosperous kingdom.

The **empire flourished** under his leadership, marked by **military strength, religious tolerance,** and **cultural patronage**. However, after Ranjit Singh's death, the **internal conflicts, court intrigues,** and **British interference** led to its **decline**.

The **Anglo-Sikh Wars** and the eventual **annexation of Punjab in 1849** brought an **end to the Sikh Empire**, making it part of **British India**.



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